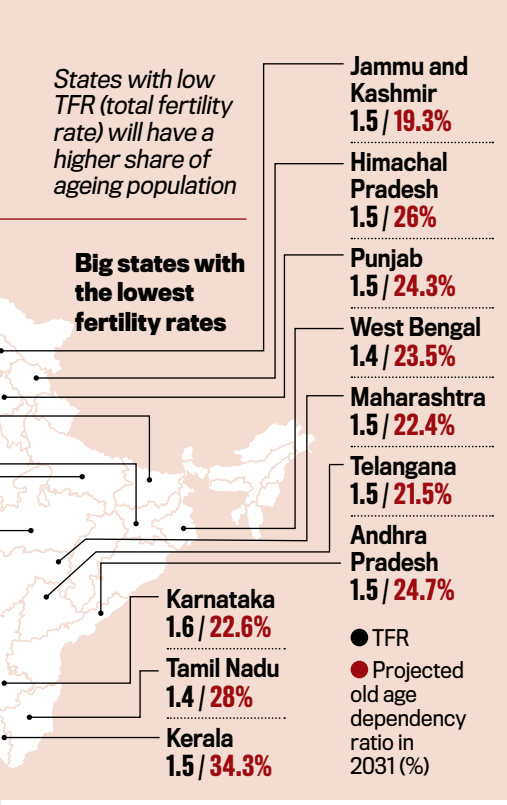
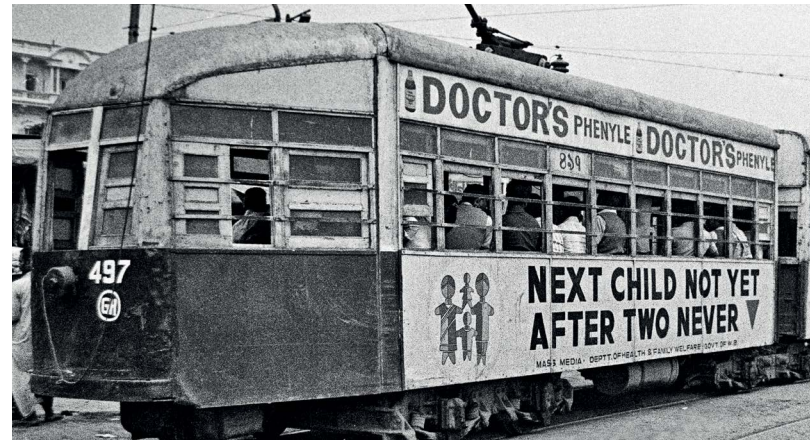


Source: National Commission on Population, MoHFW, 2019; 2011 Census, population projections



GETTY IMAGES

"INDIA BEGAN A HUGE POPULATION CONTROL PROGRAMME IN THE 1970S WHEN IT WAS 650 MN... IF WE THOUGHT 650 MN WAS TOO LARGE IN THE 1970S, WHY DO WE THINK 1.7 BN (PROJECTED POPULATION FOR 2054) IS TOO SMALL TODAY?"

SONALDE DESAI, *Prof. of Sociology, University of Maryland*

confront us. The study says 75 per cent of elderly Indians suffer from chronic diseases, 40 per cent live with disabilities, and 20 per cent face mental health issues. "The demographic and epidemiological transition has shifted a major share of India's disease burden to the elderly," says Sekher, who led the LASI study.

As India ages, the demands on the healthcare systems will intensify. Chronic diseases, mental health challenges and geriatric care require immediate attention. Social security systems, including pensions and eldercare, need significant reform to prevent economic instability for the ageing population. Even the prosperous south will struggle to manage their ageing demographics without sufficient preparation. "Take Andhra Pradesh, its fertility rate is similar to Switzerland's but per capita income is 28 times lower," points out Srinivas Goli, associate professor of Fertility and Social Demography at IIPS.

WHAT INDIA MUST DO

The country's failure to capitalise fully on the population dividend highlights glaring systemic gaps. Unemployment remains stubbornly high, especially among educated youth, reflecting a disconnect between the education system and market demands. Vocational training programmes have struggled to achieve scale, and while initiatives like Skill India have made strides, they are insufficient given the magnitude of the challenge.

Education has to be the cornerstone of India's demographic strategy. Ensuring universal access to quality education, particularly for girls, can reshape the future workforce. Right now, women's workforce participation remains alarmingly low, hindered by entrenched gender roles and the lack of supportive policies. "Working women, even in economically disadvantaged communities, boost their children's well-being, education and family stability more than men," says Prof. K.S. James, director of IIPS.

With a rapidly ageing population, healthcare systems must evolve from curative to preventive models. Comprehensive social security frameworks, including universal pensions and affordable health insurance, could also provide a safety net for the elderly. "The Centre's decision to provide health insurance cover for all 70-plus elderly people is a major step in the right direction," says Sekher.

India's demographic diversity necessitates region-specific policies to address varying population dynamics. The country must explore ways to offset the population deficit in the South with the surplus from the North. Effective migration policies, underpinned by housing, healthcare and skill-building initiatives, can help bridge regional imbalances. But these are easier said than done. "Migration requires significant preparation. We need to equip our population with skills and awareness, alongside robust transport and social security systems," notes Goli. Revenue allocations to migrant-receiving states must account for this to ensure infrastructure is in place.

The calls for more babies, whether from Nagpur, Chennai or Amaravati, are unlikely to reverse established trends. "Once accustomed to lower fertility, reversal is rare," says Ghosh. As India stands at this demographic crossroads, its leaders must shift the narrative from fear of decline to one of opportunity and adaptation. The question isn't about producing more children but how to ensure that those we have today inherit a country ready to meet their needs and aspirations. ■